

Word family: **fade / faded / fading / fade-in / fade-out**

Base word: fade

Past tense: faded

Past participle: faded

Related forms: fading, faded

Useful extensions: fade-in, fade-out

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to **fade into the background**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **fade** does **not** mean that the surroundings literally disappeared.

It means that the surrounding noises and distractions **gradually became less noticeable and less important to the person’s attention**.

繁體中文： **逐漸變得不明顯、不再那麼引人注意，彷彿退到背景位置**

中文翻譯：

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to fade into the background.”

「然後，他們一戴上耳機，周圍的一切似乎便**逐漸變得不明顯，退居背景，不再那麼干擾注意力**。」

fade into the background = 逐漸變得不顯眼 / 不再重要或引人注意，彷彿退到背景中

1. **fade = colour/light/image (顏色 / 光線 / 影像) gradually lose strength or brightness — 逐漸褪色、變淡或變暗**

This is the central literal meaning.

Meaning: To gradually become less strong, bright, or visible.

Practice 1

> “The curtains **faded** after years of sunlight.”

「窗簾經過多年陽光照射後，顏色**逐漸褪淡了**。」

Practice 2

> “The evening light slowly **faded**.”

「傍晚的光線慢慢**變暗、逐漸消失**。」

fade = 顏色、光線或影像的強度逐漸減弱，變得較淡、較暗或較難看見

Useful contexts:

* **colours fade** → 顏色褪色

* **light fades** → 光線逐漸變暗

* **image fades** → 影像逐漸變淡

These are all one underlying meaning, so we should **not** artificially split them.

2. **fade** = sound/noise/voice (聲音 / 噪音 / 噪音) gradually become quieter — 逐漸減弱；慢慢聽不見

The same core concept applies to sound rather than vision.

Practice 3

> “The sound of the train gradually **faded**.”

「火車的聲音逐漸**減弱，慢慢聽不見**了。」

Practice 4

> “Her voice **faded** as she walked away.”

「她走遠時，聲音逐漸**變小，最後幾乎聽不見**。」

fade = 聲音的強度逐漸降低，直至變得很微弱或聽不見

This is especially relevant to your headphones passage.

3. **fade** = memory/feeling/emotion (記憶 / 感受 / 情緒) gradually become weaker — 逐漸淡化；逐漸減弱

This is the figurative extension of the same idea.

****Meaning:**** For a memory, emotion, impression, or feeling to gradually lose strength or clarity.

Practice 5

> “The memory of that day slowly ****faded****.”

「對那一天的記憶慢慢****變得模糊、逐漸淡忘****。」

Practice 6

> “Her anger began to ****fade**** after they talked.”

「他們談過之後，她的怒氣開始****逐漸消退****。」

****fade = 記憶、感情或印象隨時間逐漸失去原本的清晰度或強度****

Natural Chinese changes by context:

* memory fades → 記憶淡忘 / 模糊

* anger fades → 怒氣消退

* excitement fades → 興奮感逐漸減退

* pain fades → 痛楚逐漸減輕

Same semantic core: ****gradual weakening****.

4. ****fade = importance/attention/popularity (重要性 / 注意力 / 人氣) gradually become less noticeable or influential — 逐漸失去存在感 / 影響力****

This is the meaning closest to your original sentence.

****Meaning:**** To gradually become less noticeable, important, influential, or central to someone's attention.

Practice 7 — Original

> “Everything seemed to ****fade into the background****.”

「周圍的一切似乎逐漸****變得不明顯，退居背景****。」

Practice 8

> “Once the music began, the conversations around me ****faded into the background****.”

「音樂一開始，周圍的談話聲便逐漸**變得不再明顯，退居背景**。」

Practice 9

> “The issue gradually **faded from public attention**.”

「這個議題逐漸**淡出公眾視野，不再受到那麼多關注**。」

****fade = 某事逐漸失去顯著性、重要性或吸引注意力的程度****

5. ****fade = popularity/fame/success (人氣 / 名聲 / 成功) gradually decline — 逐漸衰退；不再受歡迎****

This is really a contextual branch of #4, not a completely unrelated lexical meaning.

Practice 10

> “The fashion quickly **faded** in popularity.”

「這種潮流的人氣很快便**逐漸下降，不再那麼流行**。」

Practice 11

> “His fame began to **fade** after he retired.”

「他退休後，名氣開始**逐漸減退**。」

****fade = 人氣、名聲或影響力隨時間逐漸衰退****

6. ****fade + object (顏色 / 布料 / 照片) — 使.....逐漸褪色或變淡****

Although ****fade**** is often intransitive, it can also be transitive.

****Meaning:**** To cause something to lose colour, brightness, or strength.

Practice 12

> “Strong sunlight had **faded** the carpet.”

「強烈陽光令地毯**逐漸褪色**。」

Practice 13

> “Years of exposure ****faded**** the photograph.”

「多年的曝露令照片****逐漸褪色、影像變淡****。」

****fade something = 使某物的顏色、亮度或影像強度逐漸減弱****

Compare:

> “The curtains ****faded****.”

> = 窗簾自己逐漸褪色。

> “The sun ****faded**** the curtains.”

> = 陽光令窗簾逐漸褪色。

7. ****faded = colour/material (顏色 / 布料) having lost colour or brightness — 已褪色的 ; 色澤變淡的****

****Meaning:**** Having become less bright or colourful over time.

Practice 14

> “He was wearing a pair of ****faded**** jeans.”

「他穿著一條****顏色已經褪淡的****牛仔褲。」

Practice 15

> “The sign was old and ****faded****.”

「那塊招牌又舊又****褪色，字跡已不太鮮明****。」

****faded = 原本較鮮明的顏色或外觀已逐漸失去強度的****

8. ****faded = memory/glory/hope (記憶 / 昔日榮耀 / 希望) weakened with time — 已淡化的 ; 昔日而今已衰退的****

****Meaning:**** No longer as strong, vivid, successful, or important as before.

Practice 16

> “Only a ****faded**** memory of the trip remained.”

「那次旅程現在只剩下一段**已經模糊淡化的記憶**。」

Practice 17

> “The building was a reminder of the town’s **faded glory**.”

「那座建築令人想起這個城鎮**昔日輝煌、如今已經衰退的榮光**。」

****faded** = 原本鮮明、強烈或輝煌，但隨時間已明顯減弱的**

9. ****fading** = gradually becoming weaker or less visible — 正逐漸消退 / 變淡的**

****Meaning:**** In the process of gradually losing strength, brightness, visibility, etc.

Practice 18

> “They watched the **fading** light.”

「他們看著**逐漸變暗的光線**。」

Practice 19

> “She spoke with a **fading** sense of confidence.”

「她說話時，那份自信已經**逐漸消退**。」

****fading** = 正處於逐漸減弱、褪去或消失的過程中**

10. ****fade** = film/audio transition (電影 / 音訊中的漸變效果) — 淡入 / 淡出式的漸變效果**

Here, ****fade**** can be a noun or a production term.

****Meaning:**** A gradual transition in which an image or sound slowly appears, disappears, or changes in intensity.

Practice 20

> “The scene ended with a slow **fade**.”

「那個場景以一個緩慢的**畫面淡出效果**結束。」

Practice 21

> “The editor used a **fade** between the two scenes.”

「剪接師在兩個場景之間使用了**漸變轉場效果**。」

a fade = 影像或聲音逐漸出現、消失或改變強度的製作效果

11. **fade-in / fade-out** (影音製作) — 淡入 / 淡出

These are useful family extensions.

fade-in

= an image or sound gradually appears or becomes stronger

> “The film begins with a **fade-in**.”

「電影以畫面逐漸出現的**淡入效果**開始。」

fade-out

= an image or sound gradually disappears or becomes weaker

> “The song ends with a long **fade-out**.”

「歌曲以一段長長的**聲音逐漸減弱至消失的淡出效果**結束。」

These are directly built from the core idea of **gradual change in intensity**.

12. **fade = haircut** (髮型) — 漸層短髮；推剪漸變髮型

This is a genuinely different modern noun meaning and definitely worth including.

Meaning: A haircut in which the hair gradually changes from very short near the sides/back to longer hair higher up.

Practice 22

> “He asked the barber for a low **fade**.”

「他叫理髮師替他剪一個低位的**漸層推剪髮型**。」

Practice 23

> “A **fade** needs regular trimming to keep its shape.”

「**漸層短髮**需要定期修剪才能保持造型。」

a fade = 頭髮從側面 / 後方的極短長度逐漸過渡至較長部分的漸層髮型

Common expressions include:

* **low fade** = 低位漸層

* **mid fade** = 中位漸層

* **high fade** = 高位漸層

* **skin fade** = 推至接近皮膚的漸層髮型

Important distinction: **fade** vs **disappear**

fade

emphasizes a **gradual** reduction.

> “The sound faded.”

「聲音**逐漸減弱**，慢慢消失。」

disappear

simply means something is no longer visible/present; it does not necessarily tell us whether this happened gradually or suddenly.

> “The sound disappeared.”

「聲音消失了。」

So:

fade = 漸漸消失

disappear = 消失

Important distinction: **fade** vs **vanish**

fade

Usually gradual.

vanish

Often suggests something disappears completely, sometimes suddenly.

> “The light slowly faded.”

「光線慢慢變暗。」

> “The rabbit vanished.”

「兔子突然不見了。」

Important distinction: **fade vs weaken**

weaken

Very broad: become less strong.

fade

Often suggests something gradually becomes:

- * less visible
- * less audible
- * less vivid
- * less emotionally strong
- * less noticeable

So:

> “Her anger weakened.”

is possible, but

> “Her anger faded.”

more naturally evokes the emotion **gradually dying away**.

Important distinction: **fade vs blur**

fade

= lose strength, colour, visibility, or intensity

blur

= lose sharpness or clear boundaries

> “The photograph has faded.”

「照片顏色 / 影像變淡。」

> “The photograph is blurred.”

「照片影像模糊、不清晰。」

Something can be **faded but still sharp**, or **blurred but still brightly coloured**.

Important distinction: **fade into the background vs disappear**

In your sentence:

> “Everything seemed to **fade into the background**.”

The surrounding world did **not literally disappear**.

Instead:

- * the noises became less noticeable;
- * attention shifted away from them;
- * they no longer felt dominant;
- * they became psychologically “background” information.

So the best Chinese is not simply:

「一切消失了」 ❌

but:

「周圍的一切逐漸變得不明顯，彷彿退到背景中。」 ✅

Family-extension note

Under our updated Golden Manual, these are useful members/extensions worth remembering:

* **faded** = 已褪色的 / 已逐漸淡化的

* **fading** = 正逐漸減弱 / 消退的

* **fade-in** = 淡入

* **fade-out** = 淡出

* **fade haircut** = 漸層推剪髮型

They all visibly contain **fade**, but **fade haircut** has developed into its own concrete noun meaning and should therefore be taught separately.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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fade — colour/light/image	顏色、光線或影像的強度逐漸減弱，變得較淡、較暗或較難看見
fade — sound/noise/voice	聲音逐漸減弱，直至變得微弱或幾乎聽不見
fade — memory/emotion	記憶、感受或情緒隨時間逐漸失去清晰度或強度
fade — attention/importance	逐漸失去顯著性、重要性或吸引注意力的程度
fade — popularity/fame	人氣、名聲或影響力隨時間逐漸衰退
fade something	使某物的顏色、亮度或影像強度逐漸減弱
faded — physical	原本鮮明的顏色或外觀已逐漸失去強度的
faded — figurative	原本清晰、強烈或輝煌，但隨時間已明顯減弱的
fading	正處於逐漸減弱、變淡或消失的過程中
a fade — media	影像或聲音逐漸出現、消失或改變強度的製作效果
fade-in	影像或聲音逐漸出現或增強的淡入效果
fade-out	影像或聲音逐漸減弱直至消失的淡出效果
a fade — haircut	頭髮由極短部分逐漸過渡至較長部分的漸層推剪髮型

For your original sentence

> “Then, as soon as they put the headphones on, everything seemed to **fade into the background**.”

The exact meaning is:

fade into the background = 逐漸變得不明顯、不再那麼吸引注意力，彷彿退到背景位置**

So the whole idea is:

****戴上降噪耳機後，周圍的噪音和干擾並非真的消失，而是在主觀感受上逐漸減弱，變得不再突出。****